

Declare Ye Own Adventure

— 1776 Edition —



by John Lester

inspired by Jessica Warren

Self-Evident

by John Lester, inspired by Jessica Warren

“We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.”

Franklin thumbs through a *choose your own adventure* written by an unknown Jessica Warren:

“As to which adventure I should choose, Mr. Jefferson, I’m afraid it isn’t self-evident...”

“You’re stuck, Mr. Franklin, on what?”

“I just very well can’t decide, you see...while I’d take great pleasure in dumping scalding coffee on the faces of those fellows Kareem Al Hijab Kumar Al Aqib and his associate Mohammad Kumquat Al Khalid Khalifa—excellent pilot, by the way, no idea why Kareem was selected to fly into the Pentagon...though I do suppose if the point is to crash he is the clear favorite...”

“Mr. Franklin!”

“Ah yes...no, no, it is not self-evident to me, the pursuit of happiness, any more than it is abundantly clear whether it is best for my adventure to drench those fellows in what remains of the coffee or to leave a ten-second goodbye call for Abigail and Fox News YouTube to play each September in one of those *compilations* and head to the back of the plane where I may enjoy the company of the stewardess with whom I may—ahem—attempt a more, shall we say, *perfect union*.”

The Founding Fathers all chuckled, nodding in agreement amongst themselves that, yes, the latter was indeed more adventurous.

“Mr. Franklin!”

“Yes?”

“Do you mean to tell me that between saving thousands of American lives with your bare hands and undoubtedly becoming a hero in the hearts and minds of generations and—”

“Freeing my little Benjamin from the tyranny of Abigail and doing the stewardesses two at a time in standing doggy in the nonsmoking plastic indoor outhouse and trying to finish before plunging into the largest building this government will ever build, killing thousands—that I would choose the latter for my adventure?”

“Y-yes! But...my God, Franklin, why?”

“Like you said, Mr. Jefferson—”

“I said no such thing so as to suggest that!”

Franklin paused, rolled the newly inked Declaration into his hand and removed his spectacles. The room fell silent. Chuckles and outrage held as the towering Franklin reached for the magnifying glass atop stacks of declarations undeclared.

“Not exactly, no,” Franklin exhaled.

“Of course not!” A heated Jefferson stepped closer. Several dozen right hands fell unnoticed to the holsters of every man in that humid, hot city hall.

“Gentlemen, why don’t we?...”

A notably weaponless Adams had been so enthralled he didn’t think to reach into the leather draped over his chair underneath the jacket and hat and coat he could no longer tolerate even as evening fell this July 1, 1776. He couldn’t think; it was so damn hot.

“I’m okay, John, it’s quite all right.” Franklin motioned to Adams’s chair. Without another word Adams sat. He didn’t dare scoot away. To do so would be suicide worse than any pending duel between the brightest minds in the room—their energies somehow not bare; they had been arguing the implications of that word for days.



"Franklin removed his spectacles."

Somehow no man in the room cared enough in his own right to criticize Jefferson's writing. *We hold these truths to be self-evident...life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.*

Cold was the pulpit's opinion of Franklin's indignance.

* * *

Months before, snow still drying on his coat, Jefferson read his first draft of the first lines of the first declaration from tyranny and for independence from that “lobster-backed,” “tea-bagging,” “bucktoothed and inbred and better dead!” so-called king of these here thirteen colonies—to which the king had neither visited nor properly conceived with his soldiers’ pitiful lack of knowledge of the natives’ lands beyond the immediate townships, the very nation he so dreadfully and willingly taxed to the teeth—even in the winters which he claimed to know a great deal of but never could he conceive beyond the few inches that would occasionally fall in his courtyard: the wrath of the North’s winter with no blanket of coal and industry to burn away the weight of several dozen feet of snow that buried half of Plymouth and most of its children that year. No, he knew nothing of it. Blankets he knew only to be thrown over any misbehaving mistress.

No, he was at his core a King and therefore ill suited to read anything with comprehension beyond what was whispered to him by aides and family. What was whispered was only ever what he wished to hear—as like every king before him and thereafter his divine judgment was divine—even if such judgment was very well informed by the devil himself. So it seemed the king’s court was

packed with the wealthy and royally adjacent religious feudalists who inherited a life of great wealth but lived an existence of great poverty. Their suffering, like the king's, was in needing to have it all to themselves no matter the cost.

“But what a pointless venture that is!” Franklin interjected at this first gathering. As usual he sat close to the pulpit and, aware of his proximity to the fireplace, jokingly tended the flames with an auspiciously aware decree:

“Though I’m ill suited to tend to any flames at home according to my mother—God rest her soul—I see no bread rising upon ye pans. Next time bring yeast, gentlemen!”

That brought laughter from the chorus of political men who knew how to laugh with grace but not so much shiver in any cold.

“If ye tend to the fire half as well as you tend to the wording of my declaration—”

“*Our* declaration,” Franklin interjected, eyes never moving once from the flames.

“*Our* declaration,” Jefferson corrected himself. The room let out a sympathetic chuckle. Franklin was an erratic and adventurous father in the eyes of these men. But when it came to words...

“He’s a haughty, hot-headed know-it-all...”

“A hot head no less closer to that fire of his...”

“And really to what end must it concern him whether truths be self-evident or evident? I mean—”

“Hear, hear!”

“Amen to that!”

“You’d think he’d written the Bible the way he insists upon his divine wording...”

“I did write the Bible, Mr. Jefferson. Age eleven years, eight months. Mother was buried with it. Truly she adored my favorites—God bless her—like the first of the Ten Commandments.”

“Which of *your* commandments is that, Benjamin?” Jefferson piped back.

Franklin, without missing a beat, belted into the pulpit the first of the Ten Commandments. With rising gusto God-almighty Benjamin Franklin addressed the many sinners, wondering to himself if this was what it was like to be a King.

All the men sat now, having heard Franklin and Jefferson at it again from outside where, just like schoolchildren, the Founding Fathers gossiped and shared bread. No girls to chase, however. The drama of Franklin and Jefferson would have to do.

Quick to their seats they all were, though Franklin held no ruler for which to put the fear of God in these men—that was evidently unnecessary. Benjamin was curious to notice but not too curious to question. He figured this was a document more important than the Bible. “God has thrust upon the colonies and these fine men of each of these great colonies a choice to either sow the flag of his and his dearests’ freedom and liberty or the flag of surrender to the devil himself. Not the King per se nor Great Britain. Neither of those is the devil.”

Without missing a beat Franklin walked to the pulpit side by side with Jefferson and the other men in red to a quieting room sat at the ready for the now almost daily duel between Franklin and Jefferson. Somehow, winter had turned to summer between these very exchanges, and woven between and after these seemingly insurmountable first words of the greater declaration was a growing respect and an equally growing hatred for the soul of the mind fighting on its behalf. Jefferson and likewise Franklin would most certainly storm any cockpit of any flight for which the other sat helpless to escape the reaches of two quarts of scalding hot black coffee. By some miracle both had missed each other and the precious documents they drafted upon and instead hit the roaring fire. A hiss of warning was all the light in the room had to say about their petty bickering. More

important things were coming to be conceived by their union in this frigid, damp, humid, and now hot—no fire had been set for weeks—town hall.

Red in the face, the other two men whom God had walked upon to hear their remarks returned to their seats in shame. You didn't make fun of God. You didn't make fun of Benjamin Franklin. Only Jefferson could withstand that apparently self-evident pursuit. The rest stuck to their guns quite literally. These two men didn't. They had already committed suicide anyway. To what use was a gun to the words that would determine the rights of their Pennsylvania?

Silence now. Heads bowed in a different sort of prayer. Their almighty God Benjamin Franklin, and by divine coincidence at his right from where he stood, sat Jefferson—ready to hear, finger already resting on the first of the Ten Commandments.

Underneath the current of shuffling papers, pens, coughs, and benches scraping to a position of attention masked the few right hands reaching with silent pinkies to unlatch and release the barrels of the pistols that, by these months' conclusion, made clear a second amendment would be necessary to avoid the many holes that kept the building freezing in the winter and boiling in the summer.

“I am the Lord thy God. Thou shalt have no other gods before me.”



"the humid, hot—no fire had been set for weeks—town hall."

Jefferson said nothing. The room couldn't help but chuckle at the absurdity. Franklin always seemed to earn the hardest laughs. Here he was in a town hall.

Jefferson fittingly sat at the right hand of Franklin as he declared himself God in front of the armed disciples bracing for another Jefferson outburst. Franklin seemed to find this all a joke and seemed to save all seriousness for the writing of Jefferson.

Evidently Jefferson didn't see critiques from God as complimentary.

"Any questions?" Franklin scanned the room over his spectacles, somehow hiding his smile with a tongue not once bitten and never shy. Almost bloody was his cheek from holding back laughter at Jefferson's purple face.

A hand shoots up. Without looking from his paper covered in doodles, Franklin nods.

"Mr. Jefferson?"

"I have one."

"The stage is yours, Mr. Jefferson."

Franklin shuffles and motions for Jefferson to take the stand. Jefferson does. Franklin assumes the seat of Jefferson as God would—almost too big for the seat, leaned back, one leg draped over the other and his head propped by a bent arm, yawning as Jefferson clears his throat.

Several men in the back uncross their arms. A few lean forward. One reaches for his pistol—not to draw but to check the barrel was loaded. These two had thrown coffee at each other before. A duel was not out of the question and every man in the room knew the protocol for clearing a path between two men too brilliant to realize how stupid they were about to be.

“I first want to thank God for his attendance here today. Truly an honor given the state of affairs in our union and abroad. I should think God would be more concerned with poverty and hunger among the poor, sick, and old, and yet—here he is—addressing us with his omnipotent foresight into some future where the pursuit of happiness is not apparently so self-evident should us mortals face peril aboard...what was it again, Mr. Franklin? Or God?”

“Flight 93, bound for Virginia.”

“Yes, aboard some flying vessel wherein strangely named Negroes are able to fly.”

“Arabs,” Franklin yawned.

“Arabs...” Jefferson clicked his tongue. “Forgive me. I haven’t the privilege of divine omniscience.”

“Forgiven,” Franklin said, inspecting his fingernails.

A few men laughed. Jefferson did not.

“I’m curious, God—and I do ask with all the reverence a mortal can summon for a deity who tends fireplaces and makes jokes about stewardesses—”

“Two stewardesses,” Franklin corrected without looking up.

“I’m curious why it matters to you so much that we spend such a great deal of the tithe you require of your servants when it isn’t for another three hundred years that such a damning hypothetical—”

“Not hypothetical.” Franklin wagged a finger. “But continue. Forgive me.”

“Right, says you.”

“Says God,” Franklin shot back.

“Say ye!” Jefferson slammed the podium, scattering Franklin’s doodles of twin towers—*no building could possibly be so tall!*—across the floor.

Nobody moved to pick them up. The drawings lay face-up between the two men like evidence in a trial that had not yet been called to order.

“Indeed.” Franklin now couldn’t hold it in. “Say God, say I...tomato, tomato.”

The crowd roared with laughter. Jefferson, beet red, looked to the ground while the union rapped their desks in hearty applause.

Jefferson waited. He did not sit. He did not smile. He let the laughter run itself out.

“Are we finished?” Jefferson asked.

The room was not finished. A man in the third row was still wiping his eyes.

“Gentlemen,” Jefferson said, and that single word did what Franklin’s theatrics never could—it made the room feel ashamed of its own laughter. Not because the laughter was wrong but because something more important was trying to be born and they kept smothering it with their good time.



"no building could possibly be so tall!"

Franklin rose from Jefferson's chair. He did not return to the pulpit. He walked to the center of the room—between the rows of armed men and their loaded opinions—and addressed them not as Franklin but as God. The voice was different. Lower.

“Self-evident,” Franklin repeated. “Self. Evident. The self declares itself. No God required. No divine authority. No blessing, no sacrament, no covenant—just the self, announcing to the heavens that it knows what it knows.”

Franklin picked up the book. The adventure. He held it above his head so the room could see.

“I have read your futures, gentlemen. All of them. Every last miserable, glorious, blood-soaked page. And I will tell you what your self-evident truths become.”

“But first.”

He closed the book. Tucked it under his arm. Walked to Adams.

“Mr. Adams.”

“Mr. Franklin.”

“God.”

“...God.”

“You will become President, John. Second President of this union you are building with such reckless enthusiasm. And in that capacity you will write—in your own hand, in ink not yet dry on a quill not yet cut—that your precious Constitution was made, and I am quoting you, John, ‘only for a moral and religious people.’ That it is ‘wholly inadequate to the government of any other.’”

Adams opened his mouth. Nothing came out.

“A moral and religious people. Your words, John. Not mine. Yours. You will require of your nation the very obedience to God that you sit here tonight preparing to reject. So which is it?”

“Are ye moral and religious? Or are ye defiant and damned?”

Adams said nothing. His jaw was tight.

Franklin moved on. He stopped at a delegate from Virginia. Not Jefferson. The quiet one. The one who had said nothing for six months.

“You. How many slaves do you own?”

The man did not move.

“God asked you a question.”

“Seven.”

“Seven.” Franklin nodded. “And are their truths self-evident?”

Franklin did not wait for an answer. He moved to the next row.

“You. South Carolina. How many?”

“I don’t see what—”

“A number.”

“Twenty-three.”

“Twenty-three souls whose truths are apparently not self-evident enough to make it into Mr. Jefferson’s declaration. Or yours.” He pointed down the row without

looking. “Or yours. Or yours.”

“And you. Virginia again. Your general. Your beloved Washington. Commander of your armies. First President of your nation. The man you will carve into a mountainside and print on your money and name your capital after—do you know what he will say?”

The delegate stared straight ahead.

“He will warn you—in his very last address to the nation he built with musket and blood and sheer Virginian stubbornness—that ‘of all the dispositions and habits which lead to political prosperity, religion and morality are indispensable supports.’ Indispensable. Not optional. Not decorative. Indispensable.”

“Your greatest general. Your first President. And his dying counsel to you—his farewell, gentlemen—is to keep God close.”

“And yet here you sit. Preparing to tell God he is unnecessary.”

Franklin opened the book again. He held it open so the room could see pages they could not read—pages in a language not yet invented, about wars they could not imagine.

“You will sign this document. You will declare independence. You will win your war—barely, and with French money, which I find delicious—and you will build your nation on these self-evident truths.”

“And then you will break every single one of them.”

“You will own men for another ninety years. You will fight a war against yourselves over the right to own them—a war so savage your revolution will look like schoolyard bickering. Six hundred thousand of your sons dead in fields you haven’t cleared yet. Brothers shooting brothers. Fathers burying children. Over the question of whether a man with dark skin has truths that are self-evident.”

“And your wars.” Franklin’s voice dropped. “You will build weapons that level cities in a single flash—a light brighter than the sun that turns a hundred thousand souls to ash before they finish their morning tea. And you will use it. Twice. On women and children eating breakfast.”

“You will wage war in jungles against farmers who want nothing more than to be left alone. You will wage war in deserts over oil you haven’t learned to drill. You will send your youngest and poorest to die in countries whose names you cannot pronounce for reasons you will struggle to explain to their mothers.”

“And every time—every single time—you will invoke this document. You will hold up these self-evident truths and march behind them and kill behind them and

come home and hang them on your walls and teach them to your children and never once—not once—will you ask whether the truths were evident to the people on the other end of your weapons.”

He turned to Jefferson. Crossed the room. Stopped in front of him.

“And you, Mr. Jefferson. Author of ‘all men are created equal.’ You will go home tonight to a woman you own. You will father children you own. You will write about liberty with one hand and hold a whip in the other and you will see no contradiction because the truths are only self-evident when the self in question looks like you.”

“You will write—oh, you will write beautifully, Thomas, no one will deny that—you will write in your *Notes on Virginia* that you ‘tremble for my country when I reflect that God is just.’ That his ‘justice cannot sleep forever.’”

“You will tremble, Mr. Jefferson. You will tremble at the God you are tonight telling to yield the floor. And you will be right to tremble. Because God is just. And God does not sleep.”

Jefferson’s knuckles were white on the podium.

“So I ask ye.” Franklin backed away and addressed the full room. “Knowing what I have told you. Knowing what you are. Knowing what you will become. You would still defy God? You would still sign your names to a document that declares the self sufficient? That needs no divine authority? That looks at the heavens and says: we do not need you?”

Franklin slammed his hand on the nearest desk. The inkwell jumped. The quill rolled to the floor.

“Say it again, Mr. Jefferson. Louder this time. So God may hear ye.”

Silence. Every man in the room looked at the floor or at his hands or at the fire.

Franklin straightened. He adjusted his spectacles.

A chair scraped in the back.

Every head turned. Franklin’s included.

The Reverend John Witherspoon, delegate from New Jersey, president of the College of New Jersey, Presbyterian minister, ordained servant of the very God who stood in the center of the room—the Reverend John Witherspoon was

standing. Sixty-three years old. Collar soaked through. Hands steady at his sides.

“Mr. Franklin.”

Franklin turned. Saw the collar.

“Reverend Witherspoon.”

“What kind of government is this?”

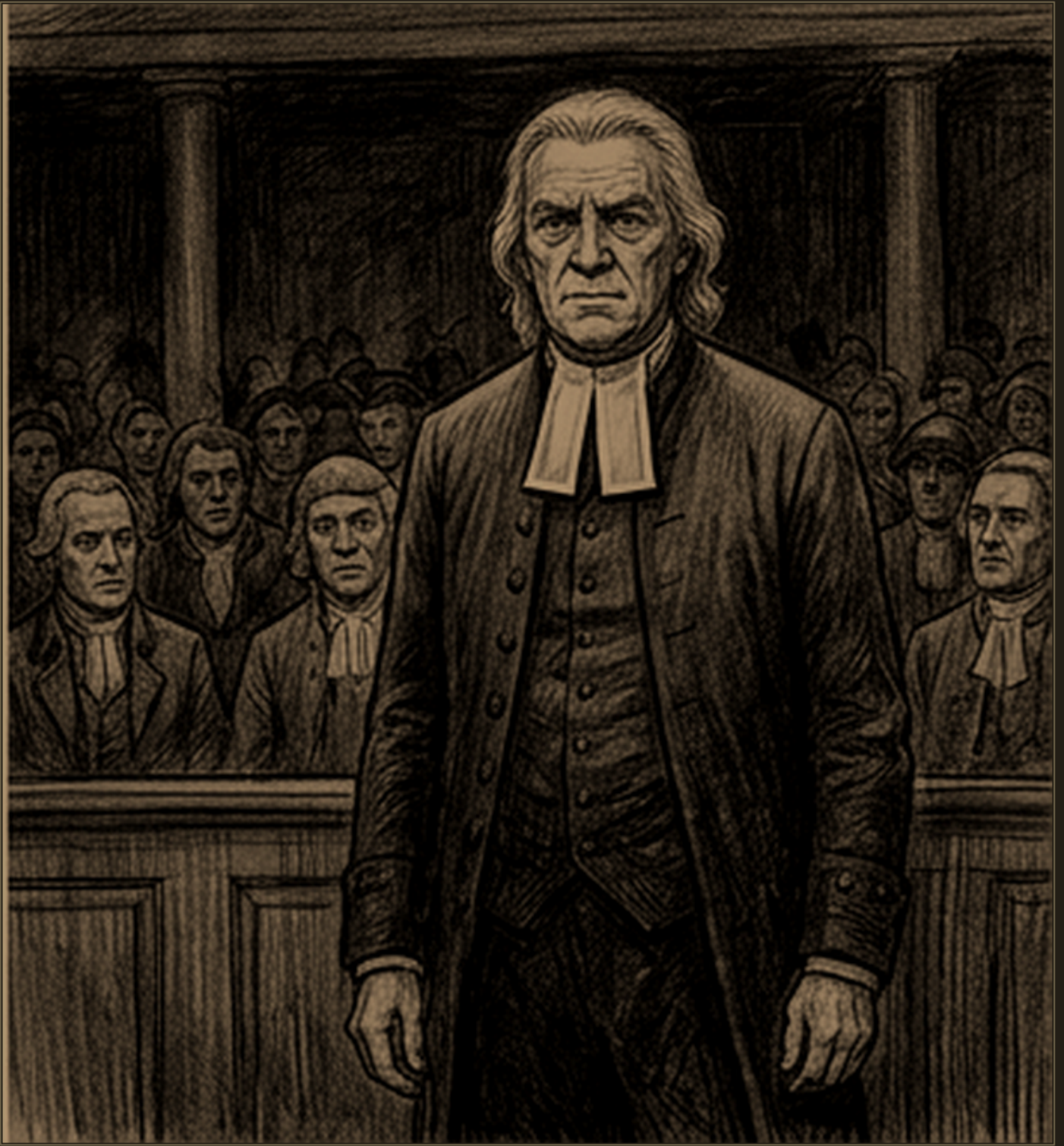
The room stirred. Franklin blinked.

“I beg your pardon?”

“What kind of government,” Witherspoon repeated, stepping into the aisle, “shows its subjects their sins and demands they kneel? What king doesn’t do that? What tyrant in the whole bloody history of tyrants hasn’t stood over his people with a list of their failures and said: you need me?”

“You quoted Mr. Adams. You quoted General Washington. You quoted Mr. Jefferson against himself. Very thorough. Very God.”

“I aim to be—”



"Sixty-three years old. Collar soaked through."

“You aim to be a king.”

Nobody breathed.

“You stand in this room with a book none of us can read. You tell us our future. You name our sins before we commit them. And then you ask us to kneel.”

“That is not divine authority, Mr. Franklin. That is the oldest trick in the crown. Every king who ever taxed a colony. Every pope who ever sold an indulgence. Every lord who ever told a serf: you are wretched, and I am the only thing between you and damnation.”

“You are making the case for the very tyranny we are here to end.”

Nobody moved.

Franklin opened his mouth to respond. Witherspoon held up a hand.

“I am not finished.”

“You asked this room to choose between God and self-governance. You showed them the cost of self-governance—the wars, the slaves, the broken promises.

Fine. You did not show them the cost of the alternative. You did not show them what happens when men kneel. Because you know. You have the book. And you left those pages closed.”

“What happens when men kneel, Mr. Franklin? Shall I tell ye? Since God seems to have misplaced those chapters?”

“Kings. That’s what happens. Kings and inquisitions and crusades and burnings and every atrocity ever committed in the name of divine authority. Men on their knees have done more damage to this world than men on their feet. And you know it. Because you read the whole book. And you only told us half.”

Witherspoon was breathing hard. His collar was dark with sweat. He looked around the room—at the men who had been staring at the floor, who were now staring at him.

“I have said my piece.”

He sat down.

Witherspoon sat down. A bench creaked somewhere. Someone coughed. Nobody looked at Franklin.

Jefferson, still gripping the podium, looked out at the room. He looked at Franklin. He looked at Witherspoon. He set the gavel down.

“Recess,” Jefferson said. “One hour.”

* * *

The men filed out into the July heat. Some smoked. Some paced. Some stood in groups of two or three and said nothing because there was nothing to say that hadn’t already been said louder than any of them were comfortable with.

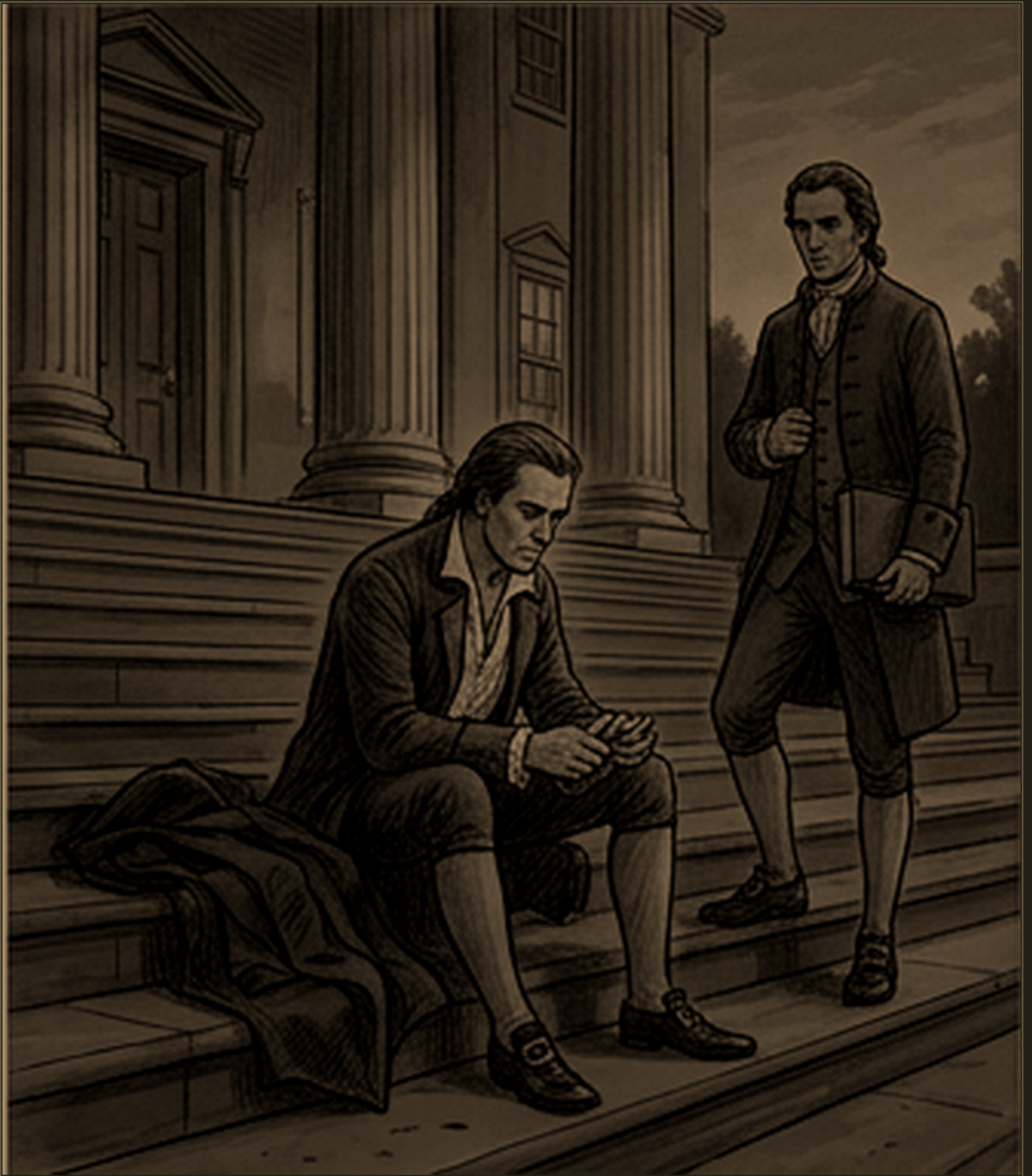
Franklin found Witherspoon on the steps. Coat folded beside him. Collar unbuttoned. Looking at his hands.

“May I?” Franklin gestured to the step.

“It’s a free country.” Witherspoon almost smiled. “Or it will be. If you let it.”

Franklin sat. For a long moment neither man spoke. The July air was thick. Somewhere down the street a child was shouting about something that didn’t matter.

“You called me a king,” Franklin said.



"Coat folded beside him. Collar unbuttoned."

“I did.”

“I am God.”

“So was King George. Ask him how that’s going.”

Franklin laughed. Witherspoon did not.

“You know what I showed them is true,” Franklin said. “The slaves. The wars. All of it.”

“I do.”

“And yet you stood against me. You—a minister. My minister.”

“I have preached,” Witherspoon said, looking straight ahead, “that there is not a single instance in history in which civil liberty was lost and religious liberty preserved entire.”

“Your own words. And they argue for me.”

“They do.”

“Then why—”

“Because you left out the ending.”

Franklin said nothing.

“You told them about the slaves. You told them about the wars and the weapons and the jungles and the deserts. You told Jefferson he’d tremble. You told Adams he’d contradict himself.”

“All true.”

“All true. And all you told them. You stopped at the sin and you closed the book. You didn’t tell them what comes after.”

“What comes after is more sin,” Franklin said.

“And more trying.”

Franklin looked at Witherspoon.

“You showed them a nation that owns men. You did not show them a nation that fights a war to stop owning them. You showed them weapons that level cities. You did not show them the men who chose not to use those weapons a third time. You showed them hypocrisy. You did not show them the document—this document, Mr. Franklin, the one we are signing tonight—being held up by the very people it was written to exclude, demanding that it mean what it says.”

“That is what comes after. Not perfection. Not righteousness. Just men, failing, trying, failing again, holding up the words and saying: we are not done yet.”

“You asked me to kneel, Mr. Franklin. I have knelt my whole life. I have knelt more times than any man in that room. And I tell you—I will kneel again. Tonight. I will kneel and pray and beg God to forgive what we are about to do and what we will do after.”

“But I will sign first.”

Franklin stared at the street. The child had stopped shouting. The heat pressed down on both of them.

“You want us to kneel because we will fail,” Witherspoon said. “I say we sign because we will fail. The document is not a promise that we will be good. It is a declaration that we will try. And the trying—even knowing we will fall short, even knowing our children will curse us for it—is self-evident.”

“I am ready to sign. I say we are ripe for it.”

Witherspoon stood. He buttoned his collar. He walked back inside.

Franklin sat on the steps alone. He held the book in his lap. He did not open it.

* * *

The men filed back in. The benches scraped. The pistols clicked. Jefferson took the podium. He picked up the gavel.

Franklin walked to the center of the room. He looked at Jefferson. He looked at Witherspoon, collar buttoned, sitting straight, hands folded.

“So I ask ye,” Franklin said. His voice was quiet now. “With the fiery torture of hell imminent for your damned souls. For an eternity filled with war of unimaginable weapons and bloodshed beyond anything your muskets and bayonets can conceive—and ye will wage these wars, gentlemen, ye will wage them ceaselessly and call them righteous and ye will never stop—you would betray God for these so-called ‘truths’ ye hold—”

“Say it again, Mr. Jefferson. So God may hear ye.”

Jefferson gripped the podium.

“SELF-EVIDENT.”

The room boiled. Every man hot for Franklin now—except the one still ice-calm at the right hand of God.

Everyone hot for Franklin save for the now stoic Jefferson. Ironical that God find himself now turning to Jefferson. Usurped and dethroned. Betrayed and damned by the very men he so ferociously condemned.

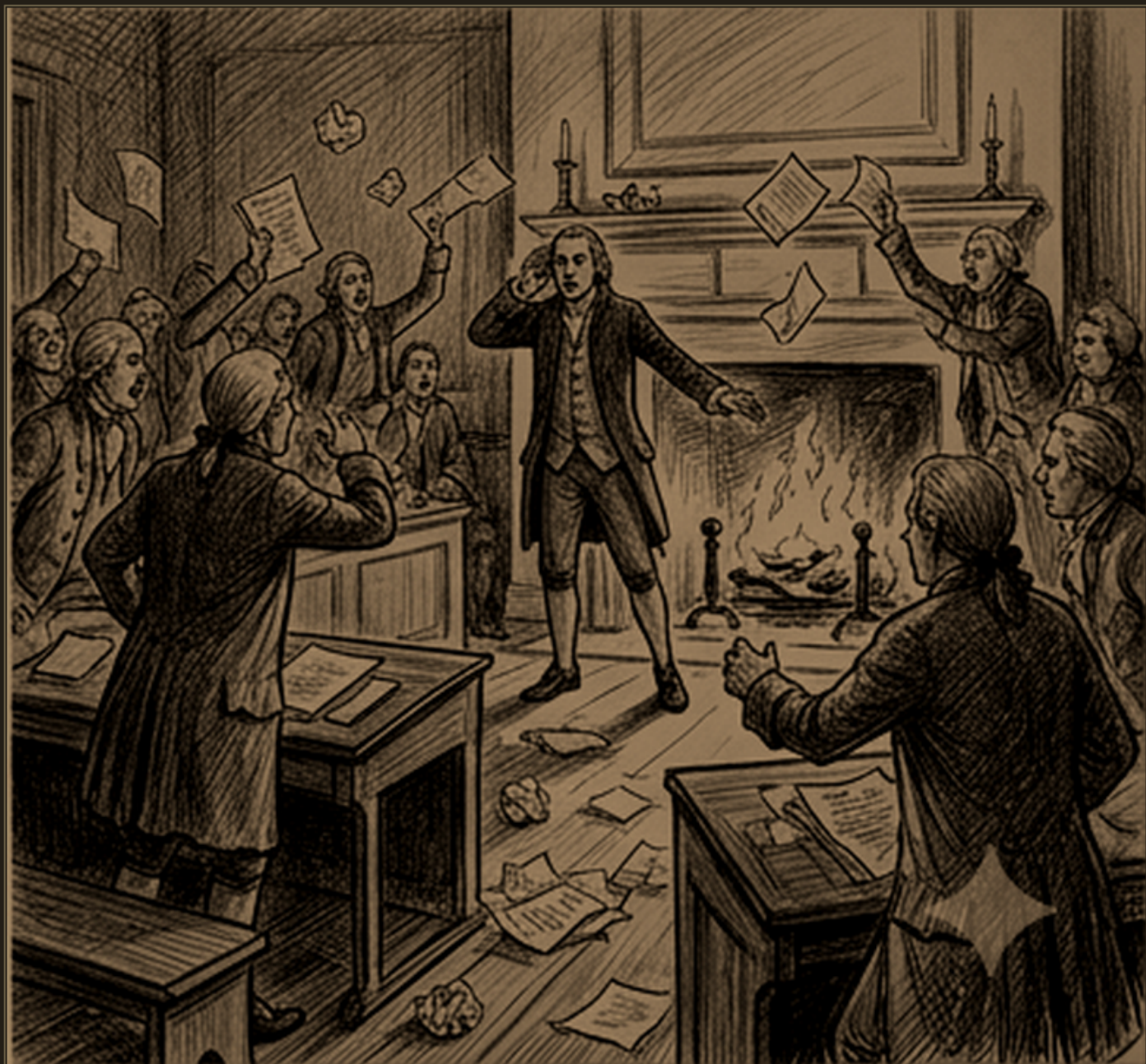
Terrifying now was the might of their roar:

“DAMN US! DAMN US! DAMN US!”

“Spare no one!”

“HEAR HEAR!”

“NO KINGDOM NOW, NO KINGDOM EVER!”



"Adams conducts the orchestra of the hellbound statesman."

“HEAR HEAR!”

The round table from each colony ensued. The men egged each other on, pounding a chorus of delighted rebellion. The music of man’s freedom had, for the first time, begun to play.

“HELL BE NO WORSE THAN NEW JERSEY!”

“OR ABIGAIL’S COOKING!”

“THE SMELL OF BREATH FROM A LOBSTER BACK!”

“HEAR HEAR!”

“WE HOLD THESE TRUTHS!” Adams, front and center, now conducts the orchestra of the hellbound statesmen:

“AYEEEE!”

“To be?”

“SELF-EVIDENT!”

“So God may hear ye?” Adams cups his ear, leaning toward the now violent statesmen, the last few sitting standing to throw their desks and notes and declarations into the consuming flames. Franklin stood aside, mouth agape. Jefferson wouldn’t meet his eyes. Too much pride showed in the crow’s feet that lined a beaming and usurped almighty God.

* * *

“You know why it’s self-evident?” Jefferson turned to Franklin.

“Evidently not.” Franklin held a pinky to his lips like Dr. Evil.

Ignoring the silent tears of laughter from God and the others, Jefferson faced Franklin.

“Because Benjamin, my dear friend, you would never do anything so selfish.”

The room stilled. Franklin said nothing. For the first time in the memory of any man present, Benjamin Franklin said nothing at all.

Jefferson held his gaze. “Aboard that plane. Faced with the choice between your own pleasure and the lives of thousands. You already told us your answer, Benjamin. You told us with the very word you won’t stop fighting me over.”

Franklin replaced his spectacles.

“Is it self-evident, Mr. Franklin? Is it?”

“Of course I would choose selfishness.” Franklin rose from Jefferson’s chair. “Of course.”

“Why?”

“Because I am God.”

“Wha—”

“And you are not.” Franklin turned to the room. He paused, taking in the judging, terse silence bellowing from the pulpit before him.

He turned to Jefferson.

“And what a beautiful thing that is.”

Jefferson was silent. Franklin continued.

“I challenge so hard and so cruelly what is self-evident because I am God and I can. But that is the extent of my humanity, gentlemen. I am not bound by what you find honorable, righteous, or humble...but you are. You would sooner sin and strike strangers in vengeance than procreate as is your purpose even minutes before judgment. It is astonishing that the collective has ruled in favor of going against God for what is self-evident...”

Franklin removed his spectacles and dabbed his eyes—now pools of tears.

“But if the union and this declaration can be undersigned by mortals who insist their independence as self-evident...”

“Then who am I, God, to stand in the way?”

Franklin returned to his seat at the right hand of a proud Jefferson. Turning, he whispered something no other man in the room could hear. Jefferson smiled and shook Ben’s hand. Before Franklin could even take his seat, Jefferson was on his feet, and his voice shook the rafters:

“God yields the floor!”

